

Perseverance Eternal Security

doc-perseverance-eternal-security

Soteriology · Perseverance · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

score 0.950
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Those truly born again will be kept by the power of God through faith unto final salvation; genuine believers cannot ultimately and finally fall away.

In plain language

The verses cited for this proposition carry some of the strongest keeping language in the Greek New Testament. In John 10:28 Jesus says he gives his sheep eternal life and they will by no means ever perish, using the emphatic double negative ou me with an aorist subjunctive plus the phrase forever, then says no one is able to snatch them, where the verb in the next verse denies capacity, not merely intent. Romans 8:38 to 39 piles up an exhaustive list of cosmic powers and says none of them will be able to separate believers from the love of God in Christ. Philippians 1:6 says the one who began the good work will complete it, and 1 Peter 1:5 calls believers garrisoned by the power of God through faith. First John 2:19 says those who departed went out from us but were never of us. Read by themselves these texts ground security on the divine side. The difficulty is that the same canon also warns in equally real grammar. Hebrews 6 describes people who were enlightened, tasted, and shared in the Spirit, then fell away, using a verb that occurs only this one time in the whole New Testament, so its exact force cannot be checked against other uses. Galatians 5:4 says you fell from grace in plain past tense, Colossians 1:23 attaches an if indeed you continue condition, and Luke 8:13 says some believe for a while and then fall away in testing. The sharpest point is one word. The very verb translated perish that John 10:28 denies of the sheep is the same verb used of the one who perished in John 17:12 and of the brother for whom Christ died in 1 Corinthians 8:11. So the keeping vocabulary cannot by itself decide whether the people in the warnings were ever truly born again, which is exactly the term the proposition assumes. Because both sets of texts are grammatically secure and the words do not rank them or tell us whether the conditions can fail or are simply how God keeps his own, the lexical pattern here is genuinely contested rather than settled.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0026	ἀγάπη	agape	love	120
G0622	ἀπόλλυμι	apollymi	to destroy	94
G0726	ἁρπάζω	harpazo	to seize	14
G0868	ἀφίστημι	aphistemi	to leave	15
G1325	δίδωμι	didomi	to give	428
G1410	δύναμαι	dunamai	be able	211
G1411	δύναμις	dunamis	power	
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	
G1601	ἐκπίπτω	ekpipto	to fall out	10

G1722	ἐν	en	in/on/among	
G2222	ζωή	zoe	life	136
G3361	μή	mē	not	
G3777	οὔτε	oute	neither	
G3895	παραπίπτω	parapipto	to defect	1
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	
G3982	πείθω	peitho	to persuade	60
G4263	πρόβατον	probaton	sheep	40
G5432	φρουρέω	phroureo	to guard	4
G5495	χείρ	cheir	hand	
G5563	χωρίζω	chorizo	to separate/leave	13

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Two grammatically secure clusters in the canon point in opposite directions on the one point the proposition asserts, and the vocabulary does not rank them. The keeping cluster is maximal: John 10:28 pairs present active didomi with ou me plus the aorist middle subjunctive apolontai and eis ton aiona, the strongest future denial Greek affords, then ouch harpasei tis, and John 10:29 uses dunatai to deny capacity, while Rom 8:38 to 39 sets perfect passive pepeismai against an exhaustive oute merism that ou dunesetai chorisai from God love. The warning cluster is equally real: Heb 6:6 uses parapesontas, a hapax, after aorist participles of genuine experience, Gal 5:4 says exepesate, you fell from grace, in the aorist indicative, Col 1:23 attaches a first class ei ge epimenete condition, and Luke 8:13 predicates pisteuousin of hearers who then aphistantai. The decisive ambiguity is lexical, not historical: apollymi, the very verb negated of the sheep in John 10:28, is predicated of the son of perdition in John 17:12 and of the brother for whom Christ died in 1 Cor 8:11, so the keeping verbs cannot by themselves fix whether the warning subjects fall inside or outside the category truly born again that the stem presupposes.

Scripture

John.10.28 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1325 δίδωμι, G0622 ἀπόλλυμι, G0726 ἀρπάζω, G2222 ζωή

Force. Didomi is present active indicative, ongoing giving of life that is aionios. Apolontai is aorist middle subjunctive third plural under ou me, the emphatic double negation, and is reinforced by eis ton aiona, which together form the strongest way Greek denies a future event. The closing ouch harpasei tis, future active indicative, denies any agent the act of snatching the sheep ek tes cheiros mou. From the giver side the keeping is stated as unconditional.

John.10.29 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3962 πατήρ, G1410 δύναμαι, G5495 χείρ

Force. The Father is named meizon, greater than all, and ou dunatai harpazein, present middle indicative of dunamai, denies capacity rather than mere intent. The image of two hands, Son and Father, grounds the security in divine power, not in the stability of the sheep.

Rom.8.38 · for · genre: epistle · figures: merism

Key terms. G3982 πείθω, G3777 οὔτε

Force. Pepeismai is perfect passive indicative, a settled persuasion standing in the present. The repeated ou strings together opposite extremes, death and life, angels and rulers, things present and things to come, height and depth, structured so that the list leaves nothing outside it.

Rom.8.39 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1410 δύναμαι, G5563 χωρίζω, G0026 ἀγάπη

Force. Ou dunesetai chorisai, future middle indicative of dunamai with the aorist active infinitive, denies any created thing the capacity to separate us apo tes agapes tou theou. The negated future of dunamai is a claim about impossibility, and the agent of the love is God in Christ, locating the bond on the divine side rather than on the believer perseverance.

Phil.1.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3982 πείθω, G1722 ἐν

Force. Pepoithos, perfect active participle of peitho, frames the writer settled confidence. The aorist middle participle enarxamenos, the one who began a good work, is the subject of the future epitelesei, will complete it, with the divine actor as agent and the believer as the field of the work. Beginning and completion are stated as one continuous undertaking by the same subject.

1Pet.1.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5432 φρουρέω, G1411 δύναμις

Force. Phrouroumenous is present passive participle of phroureo, a military term for being garrisoned under guard, with the means en dunamei theou, by the power of God, and the channel dia pisteos, through faith. The passive voice keeps God as the guarding agent, yet phroureo occurs only four times in the canon, and the dia pisteos clause ties the guarding to faith, which is exactly the joint the two readings part over.

1John.2.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1537 ἐκ

Force. Ex hemon exelthan alla ouk esan ex hemon draws a line, they went out from us but were not of us. The pluperfect memenekeisan with an in a contrary to fact conditional says that had they been of us they would have remained. The verse defines departers as people never genuinely of the body, which supports the keeping reading by category rather than by a preservation verb, but it does not state how to recognize the category in advance.

John.17.12 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0622 ἀπόλλυμι

Force. Oudeis ex auton apoieto ei me ho huios tes apoleias uses the same verb apollymi, here aorist middle indicative, of one who was numbered among those given to the Son yet perished. The shared verb shows that apollymi can be predicated of a member of the given group, so the never perish of John 10:28 does not by lexicon alone determine whether the perishing one was ever truly of the flock.

1Cor.8.11 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0622 ἀπόλλυμι

Force. Apollutai gar ho asthenon, present middle indicative of apollymi, says the weak one is being destroyed, described as the brother for whom Christ died. The same destruction verb is here applied to a brother and is tied to dying for him, which the proposition keeping verbs do not address, so the canon supplies a use of apollymi that the never perish statement does not rank.

Col.1.23 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2222 ζωή

Force. Ei ge epimenete te pistei is a first class conditional, ei plus the present active indicative epimenete, if indeed you continue in the faith, governing the promise of presentation. The grammar attaches a stated condition of continuing to the standing just described, which the keeping texts present from the divine side, so the canon places a conditional clause beside the unconditional ones without telling the reader how to combine them.

John.15.6 · complicates · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3361 μῆ

Force. Ean me tis mene en emoi is an ean conditional with the present active subjunctive mene, if anyone does not abide in me, followed by eblethe exo, kaietai, he is cast out and burned. The branch imagery is set inside the vine to which it was attached, and the lexicon does not settle whether the non abiding branch was ever a living member or a fruitless attachment, so the warning is grammatically real but referentially open.

Gal.5.4 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1601 ἐκπίπτω

Force. Tes charitos exepesate, aorist active indicative second plural of ekpipto, you fell from grace, addresses people seeking to be justified by law. Ekpipto occurs ten times in the canon and elsewhere means a thing falling off or a ship running aground, so the falling here is a real movement away from grace, though the lexicon does not by itself define whether those addressed were ever in saving grace or in a covenant standing they presumed.

Luke.8.13 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0868 ἀφίστημι

Force. Pros kairon pisteuousin, present active indicative of pisteuo, they believe for a while, and en kairo peirasmon aphistantai, present middle indicative of aphistemi, in a time of testing they fall away. The text predicates pisteuo of the very people who depart, while also saying rhizan ouk echousin, they have no root, so the believing and the falling are both stated and the lexicon does not tell the reader whether such belief is the same as the saving faith the proposition has in view.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
John.10.28	John.17.11	tsk	1
John.10.28	John.3.15	tsk	1
John.10.29	John.14.28	tsk	1
Phil.1.6	Ps.138.8	tsk	1
1Pet.1.5	1Sam.2.9	tsk	1
1John.2.19	Deut.13.13	tsk	1
Rom.8.34	Rom.4.25	tsk	1
Rom.8.32	Rom.5.6	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Heb.6.4-6 · addressed

The aorist participles photisthentas, geusamenous tes doreas, kai metochous genethentas pneumatou hagiou describe people enlightened, who tasted, and were made partakers, language of genuine experience, and parapesontas then says they fell away, with adunaton, it is impossible, to renew them. Parapipto is a hapax, occurring only here in the canon, so its precise sense cannot be triangulated from other uses, and geuomai, to taste, and metochos, partaker, can denote real participation or association short of new birth. The grammar of the participles is secure, but the lexicon cannot establish whether the subjects were ever truly born again, the term the proposition presupposes, so the warning neither confirms nor refutes the claim and can be read either as genuine believers falling or as covenant insiders who, per 1John.2.19, were never of us. Addressed but not lexically decisive.

Heb.10.26-29 · addressed

Hekousios hamartanonton is a present participle of ongoing willful sinning meta to labein ten epignosin tes aletheias, after receiving the knowledge of the truth, and ouketi apoleipetai thysia says no sacrifice for sins remains. Heb.10.29 says the offender has trampled the Son of God, counted the blood of the covenant common, en ho hegiasthe, by which he was sanctified, and insulted the Spirit of grace. Labontas marks reception of knowledge, and hegiasthe predicates a being set apart, but neither word by itself states the new birth, so the lexicon again leaves open whether the subject is a regenerate person or a covenant participant who never truly belonged. The severity is grammatically real, yet it does not by itself establish that one truly born again can finally perish, so the tension with John.10.28 stands unresolved at the lexical level. Addressed but not lexically decisive.

1Cor.8.11 · addressed

Apollutai ho asthenon, present middle indicative of apollymi, applies the same destruction verb that John.10.28 negates of the sheep, here to the brother for whom Christ died. The verb is identical, so its appearance in a never perish promise and in a perishing brother shows the lexicon does not by itself rank which use governs the disputed point. Addressed, and it sharpens rather than resolves the contest, because the shared verb is precisely why the keeping statements cannot settle the warning passages.

Col.1.23 · addressed

Ei ge epimenete is a first class conditional with ei plus present active indicative, treating continuation as a real stated condition of the standing described. A first class condition presents its protasis as assumed for the argument, not as proven fact, so the construction neither asserts that continuation is automatic nor that it can fail, it simply attaches continuing to the promise. The lexicon and syntax therefore place a conditional clause beside the unconditional keeping texts without ranking them, which is the core of the dispute. Addressed but not lexically decisive.

Concordance traversed

G0726, G0622, G3982, G5563, G1325, G1410, G5432, G3895, G1601, G0868, G4263, G2222, G0026, G1411, G3962, G5495

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

john-10-29-relative-comparative-reading at John.10.29: impact none. Witnesses differ on whether the relative and comparative read as the Father who has given them to me is greater than all, masculine, or as that which the Father has given me is greater than all, neuter. Both readings keep the security grounded in the Father greatness and the no one can snatch clause, so the keeping force is identical under either text and the disputed point is untouched.

john-10-28-didomi-tense-marks at John.10.28: impact none. Editorial sigla mark word order and a minor reading around didomi autois zoen aionion, but the ou me apolontai eis ton aiona and ouch harpasei tis clauses are stable across the apparatus, so the emphatic double negation that carries the keeping force is not variant sensitive.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. unconditional_preservation, conditional_security, means_of_perseverance

analogia scripturae invoked

unconditional_preservation: affirms · Treats the divine keeping clauses as the controlling data, ou me apolontai with eis ton aiona and ouch harpasei tis in John.10.28, dunatai denying capacity in John.10.29, perfect pepeismai against the exhaustive oute merism that ou dunesetai chorisai in Rom.8.38 to 39, enarxamenos and epitelesei in Phil.1.6, and phrouroumenous in 1Pet.1.5. It reads the warning passages through 1John.2.19, where departers were never of us, and through John.17.12 and 1Cor.8.11 as showing apollymi can be said of non genuine members, so the warnings address professors and never the truly regenerate.

conditional_security: complicates · Treats the warning clauses as addressed to real believers, the experiential aorist participles before paraprontas in Heb.6.4 to 6, the present hamartanonton and hegiasathe of Heb.10.26 to 29, the aorist exepesate of Gal.5.4, the present pisteuousin then aphistantai of Luke.8.13, and the ean me mene of John.15.6. It reads the dia pisteos of 1Pet.1.5 and the first class ei ge epimenete of Col.1.23 as genuine conditions on the keeping, concluding that final falling away is a real possibility the warnings presuppose.

means_of_perseverance: affirms · Takes both clusters as true and reads the conditional warnings as the instruments through which the unconditional keeping is actually accomplished, so dia pisteos in 1Pet.1.5 and ei ge epimenete in Col.1.23 describe how God preserves rather than a contingency that defeats preservation. On this reading the imperatives and conditionals are the appointed means by which the ou me apolontai promise is realized, and the warnings function to produce the very perseverance they require. The lexicon is consistent with this synthesis but does not by itself demonstrate it over the conditional reading.

The three lenses agree on the grammar of every individual clause. They diverge only on the referent of the warning passages and on whether the stated conditions are contingencies that can fail or means that cannot fail, neither of which the lexicon fixes, so the proposition is lexically contested rather than settled.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Scripture describes God as keeping his people through faith unto final salvation; whether one who is genuinely regenerate can ultimately and finally fall away is the open question the warning passages raise.

The qualifiers truly born again and genuine believers cannot ultimately and finally fall away build the conclusion into the subject by definitional gating, so any apostate can be reclassified as never genuine and any falling text disarmed in advance. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form removes the no true believer framing so the warning texts can be weighed on their own terms. Verdict unchanged from the prior file at disputed; this pass added the apollymi cross-cutting evidence from John.17.12 and 1Cor.8.11, the parapipto hapax finding, the first class ei ge condition in Col.1.23, the ean conditional in John.15.6, the pisteuousin then aphistantai pairing in Luke.8.13, and the aorist exepesate in Gal.5.4, and added a third means_of_perseverance lens so the contested point is represented symmetrically.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.10.28
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.10.29
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.8.38
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.6.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.5.4

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Col.1.23
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Luke.8.13
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0622
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3895
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5432
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0726
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	John.10.28

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent